

ALLIED ARMoured FIGHTING VEHICLES

Although Allied tanks seldom reached the standard of their German counterparts in terms of technical excellence, they were far better equipped to meet the demands of mass production. This was especially the case with the Soviet T-34/85 and the US M4 Sherman tanks, which were manufactured in tens of thousands and played a pivotal role in defeating the Germans on both the Eastern and Western fronts. France produced some good tank designs in the 1930s, but failed to use them effectively when Germany invaded France in 1940. British tanks often proved inadequate for combat conditions, although the up-gunned Sherman Firefly proved to be a potent battle-winning weapon.

▼ CHAR B1-BIS HEAVY TANK

Date 1936 **Origin** France

Weight 28 tonnes (30.8 tons)

Length 6.37m (20¾ft)

Top speed 28kph (17mph)

Engine Renault 6-cylinder 229kW (307hp) petrol engine

The French army's B1-bis was a formidable tank in its day, even if it was slow and not very reliable. Heavily armoured, it had the unusual distinction of being equipped with two main armaments — a howitzer for firing high explosives against enemy fortifications, and a turret-mounted anti-tank gun.

Also armed with 75mm hull-mounted howitzer and two 7.5mm machine-guns

47mm turret-mounted gun



▼ CRUISER MK VIII (A27M) CROMWELL TANK

Date 1943 **Origin** UK

Weight 27.9 tonnes (30.7 tons)

Length 6.35m (20¾ft)

Top speed 64kph (40mph)

Engine Rolls Royce V12 450kW (603hp) petrol engine

One of the more successful British tanks designs of World War II, the five-man Cromwell combined reasonable armoured protection with an effective main gun. It was widely used in a reconnaissance role because of its impressive top speed, reliability, and ease of handling.

Also armed with two 7.92mm machine-guns

Rear drive sprocket



47mm SA 35 main gun

Also armed with a 7.5mm machine-gun



▲ SOMUA S35

Date 1936 **Origin** France

Weight 19.5 tonnes (21.5 tons)

Length 5.38m (18ft)

Top speed 40kph (25mph)

Engine SOMUA 8-cylinder 142kW (190hp) petrol engine

An effective 1930s design that utilized a powerful main gun and a cleverly sloped armour, the three-man SOMUA equipped France's cavalry divisions, complementing the infantry's Char B1-bis. One drawback, however, was that the commander was also required to act as the gunner inside the very cramped turret.

76mm main gun

Also armed with a .5in machine-gun and two .3in machine-guns



► M4A1 MEDIUM TANK (SHERMAN)

Date 1941 **Origin** US

Weight 32.3 tonnes (35.6 tons)

Length 5.84m (19ft)

Top speed 48kph (30mph)

Engine Continental R975 298kW (400hp) petrol radial engine

The M4 tank was the most important tank fielded by the Western Allies, equipping the armoured divisions of the US and UK. Although easy to produce and maintain, it was inadequately armoured and its gun could not take on the Panther and Tiger tanks of the German armed forces.